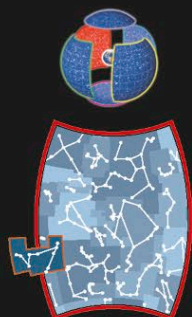


THE SEA GOAT

Capricornus



SIZE RANKING	40
BRIGHTEST STAR	Deneb Algedi (δ) 2.9
GENITIVE	Capricorni
ABBREVIATION	Cap
HIGHEST IN SKY AT 10 P.M.	August–September
FULLY VISIBLE	62°N–90°S



This is the smallest constellation of the zodiac and not at all prominent; it is situated in the southern sky between Sagittarius and Aquarius. In Greek myth, Capricornus represents the goatlike god Pan (see panel, right), who jumped into a river and became part fish to escape from the monster Typhon.

SPECIFIC FEATURES

Alpha (α) Capricorni is a wide pairing of unrelated 4th-magnitude stars. They can be separated through binoculars or even with good eyesight. Alpha-1 (α^1) Capricorni is a yellow supergiant nearly 900 light-years away, while Alpha-2 (α^2) is a yellow giant less than one-eighth that distance from Earth.

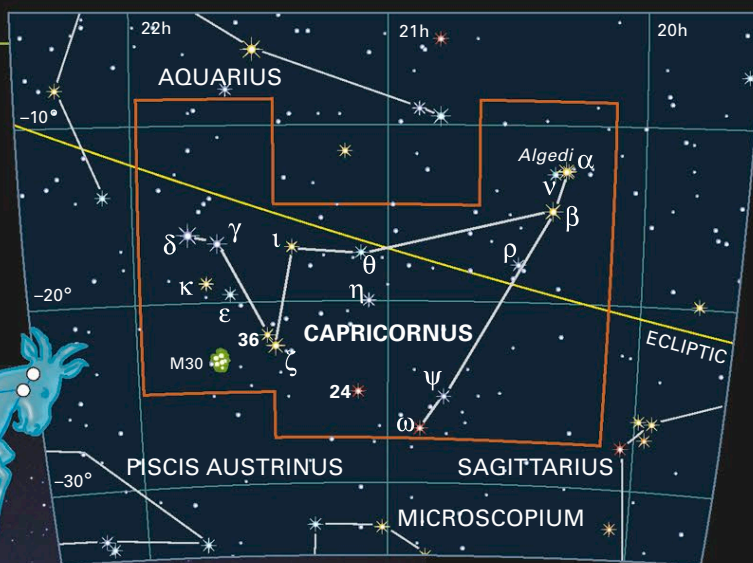
Beta (β) Capricorni is a 3rd-magnitude yellow giant with a 6th-magnitude blue-white companion that can be seen through a small telescope or even good binoculars.

The modest globular cluster M30 is visible as a hazy patch through a small telescope.

M30 $\text{H}\beta$

Chains of stars extending like fingers from the northern side of this cluster are visible through a large telescope.

THE SEA GOAT



MYTHS AND STORIES

PAN

This Greek god of the countryside had the hind legs and horns of a male goat but the body of a human. He created the pipes of Pan, also known as the syrinx, from reeds of different lengths.

PAN-PIPER

This stone statue of Pan playing his reed pipes is to be found in the garden of a castle in Schwetzingen, Germany.



CAPRICORNUS AND MARS

Mars is seen here to the left of Capricornus, whose stars form a roughly triangular shape depicting Pan as half goat, half fish.

THE MICROSCOPE

Microscopium



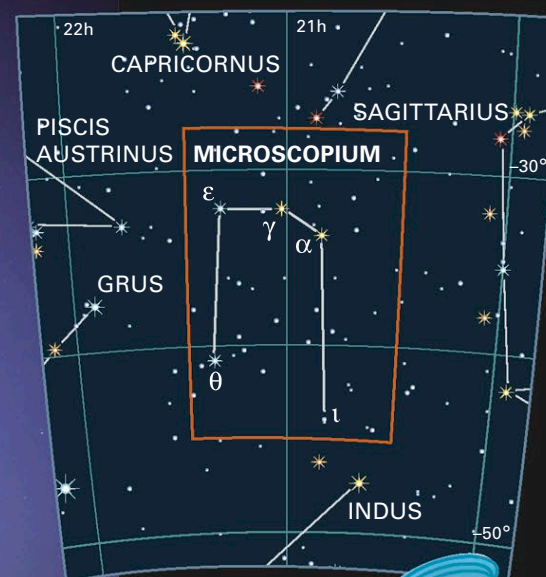
SIZE RANKING	66
BRIGHTEST STARS	Gamma (γ) 4.7, Epsilon (ϵ) 4.7
GENITIVE	Microscopii
ABBREVIATION	Mic
HIGHEST IN SKY AT 10 P.M.	August–September
FULLY VISIBLE	45°N–90°S



Microscopium is a faint and obscure southern constellation to be found between Sagittarius and Piscis Austrinus. It was invented in the 18th century by the French astronomer Nicolas Louis de Lacaille (see p.422), and it represents an early design of compound microscope.

SPECIFIC FEATURES

The orange giant Alpha (α) Microscopii, of 5th magnitude, has a 10th-magnitude companion that is visible through an amateur telescope.



THE MICROSCOPE



UNDER THE MICROSCOPE

Microscopium is a faint and almost featureless constellation. It lies near Capricornus and the much more conspicuous Sagittarius.